



Vector

AI plans. **You deliver.**

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GUIDE FOR SOLOPRENEURS

Planning for Unplanned **Sick Days**

The four-piece net that lets you stop for
two days without everything collapsing.

THE PROTOCOL, BEFORE THE FEVER

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WHAT YOU'LL FIND INSIDE

Four pieces to build, once.

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BEFORE YOU START

This guide takes 15 minutes to read and a week to put in place, except the cushion, which takes longer to build. Keep your calendar open: three of the four pieces get handled today, in under two hours total.

INTRODUCTION

On the morning of the fever, you don't decide. **You execute.**

That's the whole difference between a two-day stop and a week that goes off the rails.

You wake up at 102°F. Your first thought isn't "I'll rest," it's "I can't afford to stop." And there you are, making the most expensive decisions of your month with the foggiest judgment of your year.

A backup plan is a terrible thing to build with a fever, so you improvise it, and you improvise it badly.

THE CORE IDEA

The net doesn't exist by default in this work, and no one is going to install it for you. The useful question isn't "will I get sick," it's "what holds the day it happens."

The four pieces that follow get built while you're well. When the day comes, you have nothing left to decide: you open the protocol, you follow the five steps, and you go back to bed.

What working sick **really** costs you.

Getting up anyway looks brave. It's actually the most expensive calculation you'll make this week, in three places we rarely add up.

1

The work you redo

You produce at half strength, you take twice as long, and you plant errors you'll fix later with a clear head. A day wrenched out of a fever often costs a day of corrections.

2

The illness that drags

Pushing delays your recovery. Two days of a clean stop become five days at half capacity, then a relapse. The time you think you're saving, you lose twice over.

3

The client who notices

Sloppy work damages your reputation more than a delay announced calmly. You protected the date and sacrificed the work, when the client would have accepted the opposite without blinking.

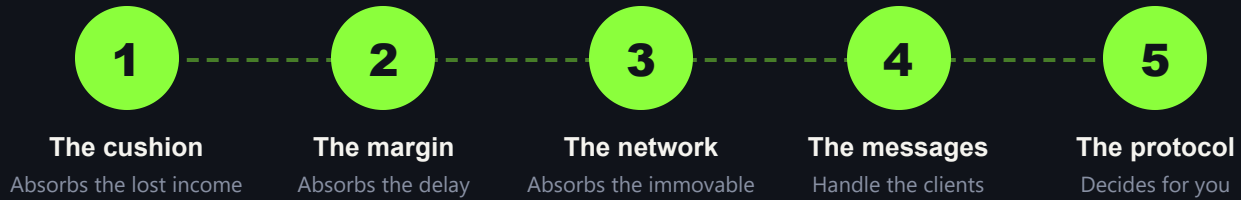
And the cost nobody counts.

By never stopping, you end up losing the ability to stop at all. It's the same mechanism as burnout: pushing on an empty reserve doesn't refill it, it digs the hole deeper. The four pieces that follow don't ask you to be more disciplined, they take the decision away from you at the moment you're least fit to make it.

Working at half capacity for five days costs you more than stopping cleanly for two.

Four pieces built ahead. One protocol on the day.

None of them takes discipline. All of them take an hour, once.



HOW TO READ THE NET

Pieces 1 and 2 give you the right to stop: money that holds and a schedule that bends. Pieces 3 and 4 handle the outside world while you're gone. The protocol chains them in the right order, so you have nothing to invent with a fever.

The cushion.

A day not working is a day not paid. As long as that's true, your body has no permission to give out, and that constraint is exactly what makes you work sick. The cushion loosens it.

Not savings. Your own sick pay.

An employee gets paid days when they're ill. You pay yourself those days, in advance. Seen that way, the cushion stops being a virtuous project you postpone and becomes a line of expense like your insurance: the price of being able to stop.

How much

Add up one month of fixed expenses, personal and business together. Your first target isn't six months, it's **one week**. A single week set aside already changes your answer on the morning of the fever. Three weeks give you real room. Beyond that, you're building for slow seasons, not for illness.

How, on a variable income

A fixed monthly amount won't survive a slow month, and you'll quit after two misses. Work by percentage instead: every time a client payment lands, you move 5 to 10% of it the same day. Big months fill fast, small months break nothing.

EXERCISE · 10 MINUTES

Open a separate savings account with no debit card attached, and name it "Sick Leave" rather than "Savings." Set your percentage today and note it on your invoice template: the transfer happens by hand, the day the payment lands, while you have the amount in front of you. An account that takes two days to reach rather than two minutes is an account that still exists in six months.

What **one week** of cushion changes.

The cushion isn't there to cover a long illness. It's there to remove the financial panic of the first morning, the one that makes you open your laptop instead of sleeping.

THE SAME TUESDAY, TWO BANK ACCOUNTS

	NO CUSHION	WITH A ONE-WEEK CUSHION
Your first thought	"How much am I losing today?"	"When do I start again?"
Your decision	You work at 40%	You stop cleanly
Your week	Five diminished days	Two days off, three full
The month after	You catch up and relapse	You came back whole

THE CLICK

The cushion doesn't buy you rest, it buys you the freedom to choose with clear judgment. With a few weeks of expenses set aside, the decision to stop becomes a medical one again instead of an accounting one made at 102°F.

The margin.

A calendar packed to the edge has zero tolerance for the unexpected. The smallest grain of sand derails everything, and illness is not a grain of sand.

The rule: never plan at 100%

Set aside roughly one day in five, or 20% of your billable hours, with nothing on it. That reserve isn't sitting idle waiting for you to get sick: it absorbs the client who answers three days late, the call that runs long, the deliverable that comes back with revisions. Those surprises show up every week, not once a year, and illness is only their biggest version.

The day you do have to stop, that same reserve gives you peace of mind: two days slot into it without a single deadline having to move, and you pick back up at your normal pace instead of returning in catch-up mode.

The Tuesday test

Look at your week and ask one question: if I lose Tuesday, does the rest hold? If the answer is no, you don't have a full week, you have a fragile one. Those are two different things, and only the second is dangerous.

Why it always disappears

The margin gets eaten because it looks empty, and an empty slot attracts a meeting. Give it a name in your calendar: a block called "Buffer" defends itself, a white square never does.

EXERCISE · 5 MINUTES

Open next week's calendar, block half a day, name it, and treat it like a client meeting. If nothing derails, it goes to admin or to getting ahead.

Two days lost, **two outcomes.**

Same illness, same workload. What changes is what was in the calendar before it arrived.

CALENDAR FULL AT 100%

The two days have nowhere to go.

Everything slides into next week.

Which was already full.

You work evenings to catch up.

You relapse or you deliver badly.

CALENDAR PLANNED AT 80%

The buffer absorbs the first day.

The second moves two deliverables by 48h.

Two emails, and it's handled.

Your following week stays normal.

You come back at full capacity.

WORTH REMEMBERING

The margin isn't a luxury for solopreneurs with time to spare. It's the only mechanism that turns a surprise into a simple delay. Without it, every surprise becomes a debt of work you repay in the evening.

The backup **network.**

Most deliverables can move by 48 hours. But for some, the deadline is immovable: a launch, an event, a file that costs you the client if you drop it. Those are the only ones you need someone for.

Two or three people, not an agency

Look for people in your field, at a level comparable to yours, someone you'd hand a client to without wincing. You need to know who to call before you need them, rather than the morning you're stuck in bed. And since they carry their own workload, aim for two or three rather than one: the person you think of first may well be swamped that day.

The reciprocal pact

The ask is simpler than it sounds, because it runs both ways: I cover you if you go down, you cover me if I go down. Almost nobody refuses, because everyone in this line of work has had that morning.

What gets decided now, not on the day

Three questions to settle in advance, impossible to negotiate with a fever: who invoices whom, at what rate, and who keeps the client relationship. The simplest answer works almost every time: they invoice you, you invoice your client as planned, and the relationship stays yours.

EXERCISE · 20 MINUTES

Write to two people this week: "I'm setting up my plan B for getting sick. Would you be interested in covering each other for the truly immovable emergencies? It happens once or twice a year, and I'm offering you the same on my end."

The file that makes a handoff **possible in an hour.**

Having someone to call is useless if that person needs a full day to understand the file. A handoff comes down to four pieces of information, kept current for your active clients only.

THE HANDOFF FILE, PER ACTIVE CLIENT

- 1 Where the files are**
The exact link, with access already shareable. Not "in my Drive."
- 2 What's due, and when**
The next deliverable, its date, and the expected format.
- 3 The context in five lines**
What the client actually wants, what they dislike, and where the project stands.
- 4 The tone**
Formal or casual, first names or not. That detail is what avoids a false note.

THE CLICK

This file isn't only for illness. It serves you the first time you delegate, when you go on vacation, and when you come back to a project you set aside. You're not writing it for a rare case.

The messages **written in advance.**

When illness hits, your client communication happens in two lines, not ten. The reflex is to over-explain, to drown in apologies, to promise you'll make it up that same evening. That's exactly what not to do, and exactly what you'll do if you improvise.

A serious client doesn't need the details of your symptoms. They need two things: what's shifting, and when you're back. Everything else adds noise and weakens your message.

Why apologizing works against you

Cascading apologies suggest something abnormal just happened, and therefore that you're unreliable. A shift you own and communicate clearly proves exactly the opposite. Most clients respond well to plain honesty, because they live the same thing on their end.

You don't have to apologize for having a body. You just have to say **what's moving and when you're back.**

Write these three messages today, while you're clear-headed. The day you need them, you'll only have to copy them, change the dates, and go back to bed.

Three messages. Two lines each.

Keep them where you'll find them with a fever: a pinned note, an email draft, a file on your desktop.

TEMPLATE A · THE SIMPLE SHIFT

Hi [First name],
I'm sick today, I'm back [day]. Your delivery moves to [new date], I'll confirm the moment I return.
[Your name]

TEMPLATE B · THE IMMOVABLE DEADLINE

Hi [First name],
I'm sick and I won't be able to deliver [project] by [date]. Since the deadline can't move, [backup's first name] is taking over and already has the full file. You can write to them directly at [email]. I'm back on the project [day].
[Your name]

TEMPLATE C · THE RETURN

Hi [First name],
I'm back. [Deliverable] arrives [date], as agreed. Thanks for your patience.
[Your name]

THE THREE RULES

No symptoms. No promise to work evenings to make it up. No "sorry" more than once. What's moving, when you're back, and you send.

Five steps, in this order.

You're opening this page with a fever. You have nothing to decide, nothing to weigh. You follow the five steps and you close it.

1

Assess, before you open your laptop

One honest question: would I hand this work to a client in the state I'm in? If the answer is no, you won't deliver it any better in four hours. You stop.

2

Sort what's actually due today

Run through your day and split it in two: movable by 48 hours, or immovable. Immovable means an external date you don't control, one whose delay costs you the client. Almost everything is movable. Three minutes here save you from treating ten emergencies where there are none.

3

Notify, once

Template A for everything that shifts. Template B for the immovable one, after a call to your backup. You send, you don't reread it fifteen times.

4

Actually unplug

Notifications off, auto-reply on, and the one move that truly works: the laptop in another room. A half stop rests nobody and drags everything out.

5

Come back at 70%

On your first day back, you resume at a normal pace, not double. Making up two days in one is the move that causes the relapse. Start with the nearest deliverable, not with your inbox.

IF YOU REMEMBER ONE THING

Almost everything is movable by 48 hours. The reflex that costs you isn't sorting badly, it's not sorting at all and treating the whole day as an emergency.

Rest **isn't an admission of weakness.**

It's an operating decision, same as paying your taxes or renewing your insurance. Nobody feels guilty about renewing their insurance.

You were taught to measure your seriousness by your ability to never stop. In a salaried job, that reflex is framed by rules that protect you in spite of yourself. On your own, nobody stops you, so the reflex runs empty until your body decides for you.

What you actually get back

Two days of a clean stop return full capacity for the rest of the month. Five days of half presence return a few weeks of average output and a risk of relapse. The gap between the two costs you far more than your two days off.

WORTH REMEMBERING

No one is coming to replace you. But nothing forces you to face illness bare-handed either. The net, you can string it yourself, one thread at a time, on the days you're well.

And the day the fever climbs, **it'll already be there.**

Two hours today, a net for the year.

Three of the four pieces get built in a single sitting. The fourth takes months, so it starts today.

Today, in two hours

- 1 Your three message templates**
Written and kept within reach.
- 2 Two emails for the reciprocal pact**
Four lines each. You already know who.
- 3 Your margin, named in the calendar**
Blocked across the next three weeks.

This month

- 4 The “Sick Leave” savings account**
Separate, no debit card, and your percentage set.
- 5 The handoff file**
For your active clients only.

THE TRAP TO AVOID

Waiting until the cushion is full before building the rest. The other three pieces cost zero dollars and cover most cases. Start with them, today.

The net is simple. Keeping it strung, less so.

The four pieces get built in one sitting. What undoes them is the month that follows.

The margin gets eaten by a client in a hurry, because a free slot always looks like availability. The handoff file goes stale without you noticing. And on the day, the hardest question is still wide open: what is genuinely immovable this week, and what can move by 48 hours? With a fever, everything looks urgent.

WHAT VECTOR HOLDS FOR YOU

- Your margin is planned and defended in your calendar, instead of vanishing at the first request.
- You see at a glance what's genuinely immovable this week, without reconstructing it from memory.
- After two days off, your plan reorganizes itself instead of asking you to replan everything by hand.
- Your follow-ups don't fall through the cracks while you're gone.

The net stays yours. Vector just makes sure it's still strung the day you fall.

JOIN VECTOR

Vector opens **soon.**

The tool isn't open to the public yet. The waitlist gets you in the day we open, and the first fifty signups get a 21-day Acceleration trial instead of 14, with 100 extra AI credits as a gift.

Foundation

Free **FOR LIFE**

Up to 2 active projects · Weekly briefing ·
Automated calendar planning · No credit card.

Acceleration

RECOMMENDED

\$35 / mo

Unlimited projects · Arthur, your Chief Planning Officer · 100 AI credits per month · All AI features included.

Delegation **SOON**

\$79 / mo

Everything in Acceleration, plus Alfred, your AI Chief Operating Officer, who executes simple tasks on demand.

Propulsion **SOON**

\$119 / mo

Everything in Delegation, plus AI employees for your recurring tasks and reports in your own branding.

NO RISK

The Foundation plan is **free for life**, no credit card. At opening, you get your full Acceleration trial included, to test everything before you decide.

Vector.

NEXT STEP

String your net while you're well.

You have the four pieces and the protocol. You can build it all this week, by hand. Or let Arthur guard your margin, track what's genuinely immovable, and replan for you the day you have to stop.

Join the waitlist →

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